SPECIAL REPORT
GUJARAT



FALLING APART
The collapsed Morbi suspension bridge

PTI

BRIDGES TO DISASTER

A string of recent collapses across Gujarat reveals a deadly mix of official apathy, decay and corruption

SUSPENSION BRIDGE, Morbi
OCT. 2022

The 19th-century pedestrian bridge over the Machchhu river collapsed just days after it was reopened following repairs. Overcrowding during Diwali celebrations was cited as a reason. A forensic report highlighted **rusted cables, broken anchors and loose bolts** as causes. Ten people were charged with culpable homicide not amounting to murder

141 killed, over 180 injured

On July 9, the image of a tanker hanging precariously on the edge of the broken Gambhira bridge at Padra in Gujarat's Vadodara district made for a haunting visual of trust betrayed, promises undone. A 10-15-metre concrete slab between two of the bridge's 23 piers collapsed suddenly, forcing several vehicles to plunge into the Mahisagar river, claiming 20 lives in a few minutes.

This was no isolated incident. Over the past three years, a spate of collapses involving the state's urban infrastructure has cast serious doubt on the BJP's much-vaunted 'Gujarat model'—a narrative built largely on the optics of wide roads, expansive flyovers and marquee projects like the Sabarmati Riverfront. At least six bridges and flyovers—some still under construction—have crumbled during this period, resulting in the deaths of over 160 people. In August 2024, most parts of Vadodara city were inundated for three days as the Vishwamitri river swelled; in June 2025, Surat encountered a similar fate. Not to mention the potholed roads that cause accidents almost every day, triggering public outrage.

On July 8, protests erupted following the death of a biker on NH 48 near Valsad after he skidded over potholes, and was run over by a truck. Locals held demonstrations at multiple places, terming the road 'highway to hell' and a 'death trap'. Fatalities on roads caused by potholes are classified 'accidents', with no investigation or accountability.

The rising anger among the urban middle class—the BJP's core voter base—has given the government much cause for worry, especially with urban local body elections scheduled early next year. Incidentally, Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel holds the urban development, and roads and buildings portfolios. Following the Gambhira incident, the roads and buildings department suspended four officials. Several district collectors instructed the contractors to immediately repair the damaged roads at their cost. Municipal commissioners were asked to oversee work done on potholed roads, live photographs of which were posted by the BJP on social media. In the past six months, the roads and buildings department has closed 178 of the 1,800 inspected bridges to vehicles. The Sardar Sarovar Narmada Nigam Ltd has also surveyed hundreds of its bridges over canals, closing 53 to traffic.

THE ROT WITHIN

What explains this sudden collapse of infrastructure? The short answer, say experts, is systemic corruption. "It is not just about money anymore," says an industry insider. "Many government engineers are not only unwilling, but also unqualified and ill-equipped to carry out effective oversight. Almost all government tasks are outsourced to Project Management Consultants (PMC) and oversight is done by Third Party Inspectors (TPI), reports merely signed by engineers to take the fall when a disaster happens. There is a nexus of contractors, PMC and TPI—all politically connected entities—that control much of the trade with their inflated costs."

After every incident, engineers are suspended, but by then they would have allegedly amassed enough illicit wealth to not miss the 25 per cent salary cut. Besides, suspension does not deprive them of retirement benefits. "The 'consultant culture' began in the '80s. Before that, engineers did inspections and took responsibility for every signature. We greased their palms then too, but now, with consultants preparing the reports, engineers are often unaware of what is actually happening," says a contractor.

The Gambhira incident bears ominous similarities with the November 2022 Morbi tragedy, in which 141 people died. The 19th-century bridge was reopened after incomplete repairs done by a local clock-making company without the requisite safety certification. Three years later, as the 40-year-old Gambhira